CASE STUDY REPORT: ARCTIC GEOPOLITICS

Strategic Competition, Environmental Shifts, and the High North Security Architecture

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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This case study evaluates the geopolitical dynamics of the Arctic, a region situated at the convergence of shifting international relations, rapid climate change, and the strategic ramifications of Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine. The core geopolitical friction centers on the transition from the post–Cold War posture of "High North, Low Tension" to heightened great power competition. This shift is marked by the expansion of NATO, the disruption of critical regional governance mechanisms like the Arctic Council, and increased Chinese economic influence in the Russian Arctic. Primary findings indicate that while climate change opens theoretical economic opportunities and navigation routes, it simultaneously acts as a destabilizing catalyst. Mitigating future escalation will require sustained allied cooperation, investment in maritime capabilities, and the diplomatic preservation of governance frameworks despite deep political fractures.

2. INTRODUCTION & BACKGROUND

Environmental Context: The Arctic Circle (66.5°N) is experiencing global warming at an accelerated rate—potentially three times faster than the rest of the planet. Shrinking sea ice reduces solar reflection, accelerating heat retention, while the Greenland ice sheet has continually lost ice over the past 25 years. Summer sea ice loss could lead to ice-free conditions in the Arctic Ocean as early as the 2030s, altering ocean accessibility and physical geography.

Scope and Significance: Home to approximately four million people, the Arctic serves as both a geographical area and a critical geopolitical framework—often dubbed "America's Fourth Coast". It acts as an amplifier of external strategic decisions, where international rivalries directly impact regional stability, global sea routes, environmental conservation, and local populations.

Central Thesis: Russia's invasion of Ukraine, alongside systemic climate change, has permanently altered the Arctic's security ecosystem—ending the era of "High North, Low Tension" and transforming the region into an arena of active great power rivalry between NATO, Russia, and non-Arctic actors like China.

3. KEY ACTORS AND STAKEHOLDERS

Russian Federation

Holds 20% of its landmass and about half of the Arctic coastline within the Arctic Circle, accommodating roughly two million Arctic residents. Russia relies heavily on the Arctic for economic development, particularly through undiscovered conventional oil and gas reserves, and actively promotes usage and tariffs for the Northern Sea Route (NSR).

United States

Positioned as an Arctic power via Alaska, focusing policy through its October 2022 *National Strategy for the Arctic Region*. The U.S. faces strategic limitations due to its non-ratification of UNCLOS and a need for improved polar icebreaking and deep-water port infrastructure.

Finland & Sweden

Long-standing neutral states that shifted their national security calculations following Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine. Finland’s NATO accession in April 2023 added an 832-mile land border with Russia, while Sweden's entry moves the region to a state of seven NATO members opposing one (Russia).

Canada, Denmark (Greenland/Faroe Islands), Iceland, Norway

Primary NATO states in the region. Norway assumed the two-year chair of the Arctic Council in May 2023, prioritizing oceans, climate/environment, sustainable economic development, and Arctic populations.

Non-Arctic Observers (China, EU, Others)

China self-identified as a "near-Arctic state" in 2018 and has funneled over $90 billion into Arctic energy and resource projects over the last decade. EU nations (notably Belgium, France, Spain) increased Russian LNG imports by 50% post-sanctions.

Indigenous Populations

Approximately 500,000 Indigenous people reside in the Arctic across traditional borders, represented as Permanent Participants in the Arctic Council. Climate change threatens traditional hunting and food security; in Alaska, nearly 60% of Native communities are "environmentally threatened".

4. CORE GEOPOLITICAL DIMENSIONS

DIMENSION	KEY FRICTION POINTS & FINDINGS
🏔️ **Territorial Claims & Maritime Boundaries**	• All eight Arctic states claim 200-nautical-mile Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZs). • Overlapping continental shelf claims exist over the Lomonosov Ridge (Canada, Russia, Denmark). CLCS issued non-binding recommendations for Russia in Feb 2023. • U.S. is at a legal disadvantage due to non-ratification of UNCLOS.
🚢 **Trade Routes & Navigation**	• Russia seeks control/tariffs over the Northern Sea Route (NSR). • Non-Russian traffic dropped in 2022: only 36 of 314 ships were non-Russian flagged; COSCO sent zero ships along NSR in 2022. • Ice-free summers expected in 2030s, but navigation remains complex.
🛢️ **Resource Exploitation**	• USGS estimates 13% (90B barrels) of undiscovered oil is in the Arctic. • 2021 CAO Fisheries Agreement protects central Arctic high seas against IUU fishing through 2037.
🎖️ **Militarization & Security**	• NATO expands to 7 Arctic states vs. Russia; Finland added an 832-mile NATO-Russia border. • High North prioritized by NATO's Allied Command Transformation for transatlantic resupply.

5. CRITICAL ANALYSIS & CONFLICT DRIVERS

- **Drivers of Conflict & Strategic Realignment:** Western sanctions post-invasion isolated Russia, forcing it into a closer strategic alignment with China. Chinese capital ($90B invested) supports Russian energy extraction and Belt & Road goals in global spaces.
- **Climate Change as a Threat Multiplier:** Physical warming opens sea access, triggering competition over shared maritime commons and energy reserves while simultaneously destabilizing human security for Indigenous populations.

- **Breakdown of Governance Frameworks:** Cooperation in the Arctic Council paused following the 2022 invasion; the Arctic Coast Guard Forum remains dormant. Functional technical guardrails like the IMO Polar Code and CAO Fisheries Agreement remain operational exceptions.

6. STRATEGIC IMPLICATIONS & FUTURE SCENARIOS

- **Transatlantic Security Integration:** NATO will increasingly integrate High North logistics, surveillance, and polar exercises into core operations.
- **Sino-Russian Arctic Axis:** Economic isolation will deepen Russian dependency on Chinese investments along the Northern Sea Route and energy sector.
- **Friction in Global Commons:** Heightened competition over unmapped seabeds and navigation routes will increase operational demands on U.S. and allied naval and coast guard forces.

7. CONCLUSION & POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

The post–Cold War posture of "High North, Low Tension" has permanently transitioned into structured great power competition. To secure strategic interests and stability in the region, the following key policy actions are recommended:

1. Expand Polar Fleet Capabilities
Fully fund and accelerate the U.S. Coast Guard's *Polar Security Cutter* program to maintain operational presence and ensure maritime domain awareness.

2. Build Infrastructure in Nome, Alaska
Expedite construction of the deep-water port at Nome to support maritime security, commercial transit, and emergency response capacity.

3. Sustain Multilateral Engagement
Support Norway's Arctic Council chairmanship to preserve non-security mechanisms focusing on environmental, scientific, and Indigenous welfare.

4. Accession to UNCLOS
Re-evaluate U.S. non-ratification of the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea to legally substantiate extended continental shelf rights on equal ground with international rivals.